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INEQUALITY

“What do we need all this Vatican for?”

Moshe Dayan

The attackers struck just after dawn on 18 November 2014, while the faithful were gathered inside the synagogue for morning prayers. They opened fire outside, then quickly moved inside the building, hacking at the worshippers with knives and axes. A shootout with police ended the assault seven minutes later. Four rabbis died inside, while a fifth person—a Druze policeman who was among the first responders—died in the hospital hours later. (Nearly a year later, a sixth and final individual, another rabbi, would also succumb to his wounds.)

The synagogue, Kehilat Bnei Torah, sits at the base of a steep hill in Har Nof, a largely ultra-Orthodox neighborhood in West Jerusalem. Many of the residents are English- or Spanish-speaking immigrants from the Americas. It is miles away from the Green Line, the disputed boundary between the two halves of the troubled holy city.

The bodies of the dead were still inside an hour after the attack, wrapped in their prayer shawls. A small crowd stood outside the building, chanting “death to terrorists” and “revenge”. The synagogue’s white facade, gleaming in the late November sunlight, was pockmarked with bullet holes. Workers from ZAKA, a religious organization that retrieves the bodies of the dead, were filtering in and out, collecting bits of flesh. “It was a very hard scene, a very complicated scene,” said Matti Goldstein, one of the group’s volunteers, later that morning. “The fact that the bodies are still in there after three hours… should tell you what we’re dealing with.”

It was the deadliest attack in Jerusalem in more than six years, but it came as little surprise. Four weeks earlier, on 22 October, Abdel Rahman al-Shalloudi had got behind the wheel of his father’s gray Volkswagen